Comprehensive Video Analysis Report

YouTube Videos: Skool.com & Circle.so Community Building Guides

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VIDEO 1: Skool.com Complete Setup Guide

URL: https://youtu.be/DyV_722_nZ0?si=5fYOqwuxJevffFGH

Core Features Demonstrated

Community Management Features:

- Unified chat and notifications system for managing multiple communities
- Dedicated classroom for hosting courses and educational content
- Shared calendar for scheduling community events, workshops, and coaching calls
- Leaderboards and gamification system for incentivizing engagement
- Discovery marketplace feature for finding and joining communities
- Built-in subscription management with multiple tier options
- Plugin ecosystem for automation (Zapier), webhooks, and integrations
- Comprehensive metrics and analytics for member growth tracking

Step-by-Step Setup Process

Phase 1: Initial Account Creation

- Start with a 14-day free trial (no credit card required initially)
- Enter your community group name (can be modified later)
- Provide credit card information for monthly subscription ($99/month after trial)
- Complete human verification process

Phase 2: Community Customization

- Upload community icon (recommended 128x128 pixels)
- Upload cover photo (recommended 1084x576 pixels)

- Write a clear group description explaining the community's value proposition
- Set a brand color using hex code
- Choose privacy settings: Private (hidden from search, members-only) or Public (discoverable)
- Use Canva or Photoshop templates provided for image creation

Phase 3: Member Onboarding Strategy

- Create a "Start Here" introductory post welcoming new members
- Use "Add Action" feature to require members to complete tasks (e.g., self-introduction)
- Pin the welcome post to the top of the community feed
- Set up automated direct messages to greet new members immediately upon joining
- Create membership screening questions (up to 3 questions)

Phase 4: Classroom and Course Setup

- Create courses with name, description, and cover image (1460x752 pixels)
- Organize lessons into folders for better navigation
- Create course pages using rich text editor supporting:
  - Headings, bold, italics, and strike-through formatting
  - Code blocks for technical content
  - Bullet points and numbered lists
  - Embedded videos (YouTube, Vimeo, Loom, Wistia)
  - File attachments and resource links
- Implement drip content: unlock lessons after specified days from member joining

Phase 5: Calendar Management

- Add events (Q&As, coffee hours, co-working sessions)
- Set events as one-time or recurring (e.g., every Monday at 10 AM)
- Include meeting links (Zoom, Google Meet) or physical addresses
- Enable email reminders sent one day before events

Phase 6: Gamification System

- Name custom levels (e.g., Starter, Guru, Elite)

- Set point requirements for reaching each level
- Link rewards to levels (unlock courses, bonus content)
- Display member progress on leaderboards

Phase 7: Advanced Settings and Integrations

- Connect Stripe account for payment processing
- Integrate Zapier for CRM syncing
- Add Meta Pixel for tracking ad performance
- Configure external links in community sidebar
- Set up membership screening questions

Key Tools and Techniques

Design Tools:

- Canva for creating community icons and cover images
- Photoshop for advanced image editing
- Provided templates for image specifications

Video Hosting:

- YouTube, Loom, Vimeo, and Wistia for embedding videos
- Skool does not host video files directly

Engagement Strategies:

- Required actions to spark initial conversations
- Introductory questions to encourage participation
- Pinned posts for visibility and structure
- Gamification with levels and rewards

Organization Techniques:

- Folder structure for course organization
- Pinned posts for important information
- Clear hierarchy in course structure

Actionable Insights

Simplicity Advantage: Skool's Google-like simplicity reduces friction compared to cluttered platforms like Facebook Groups, making it easier for both creators and members to navigate.

Engagement Prevention: Use gamification strategically to reward active members and prevent communities from becoming "ghost towns" with inactive members.

Unified Communication: The unified chat system is a major advantage for users in multiple communities, preventing missed messages across platforms.

Onboarding Impact: A well-crafted introduction post with clear next steps significantly improves member retention and participation from day one.

SEO and Discovery: Use relevant keywords in group descriptions to improve visibility in Skool's internal search engine and help potential members discover your community.

Strategic Pricing: The $99/month subscription model is positioned as an investment in community quality, filtering for serious community builders.

VIDEO 2: Circle.so Complete Community Setup Guide

URL: https://youtu.be/LBeNCRyoK0Y?si=k6C1DGCSWd0e0M28

Core Features Demonstrated

Platform Architecture:

- Flexible space-based organization system
- Multiple space types (Posts, Chat, Events, Courses)
- Customizable space layouts (Feed, List, Card view)
- Advanced content formatting with rich text editor
- Native live streaming and event management
- Integrated Stripe payment processing
- Tiered subscription and paywall system
- Member progress tracking and analytics

Step-by-Step Setup Process

Phase 1: Initial Setup and Branding

- Create account and define community name and URL

- Choose between public or private community
- Customize brand color
- Upload community logo (200x50 pixels recommended)
- Upload community icon (32x32 pixels)
- Toggle between light and dark modes
- Set default theme for members

Phase 2: Organizing Spaces and Space Groups

- Create high-level space groups (e.g., Member Central, Community, Coaching, Courses)
- Define individual spaces within each group
- Assign space types:
  - **Posts:** Long-form discussions and resource archives
  - **Chat:** Real-time, Slack-like communication
  - **Events:** Live interactions and scheduling
  - **Courses:** Structured learning content
- Customize each space with unique icons (emojis or custom images)
- Select layout styles for each space (Feed, List, or Card view)

Phase 3: Content Creation and Formatting

- Use rich text editor with backslash (/) command for formatting options
- Access formatting tools: headings, bullet points, dividers
- Embed YouTube or Vimeo videos directly into posts and lessons
- Attach files (PDFs, spreadsheets) to posts for member download
- Enable bookmarking feature for members to save content

Phase 4: Live Events and Streaming

- Schedule events with titles, hosts, dates, and times
- Support recurring events (e.g., every Wednesday)
- Choose live formats:
  - **Circle Live Stream:** Webinars and Q&A sessions (up to 100 participants)
  - **Circle Live Room:** Interactive meetings and hangouts (up to 30 participants)

- Enable automatic recording and replay posting
- Allow member RSVPs and calendar integration
- Send automatic email reminders

Phase 5: Online Course Building

- Organize content into Modules and Lessons
- Include featured media (video/audio) in lessons
- Add text descriptions and downloadable files
- Track student progress and completion rates
- Build and refine content in draft mode before publishing

Phase 6: Monetization and Access Control

- Connect Stripe account for native payment processing
- Create specific “products” with defined pricing (e.g., $39/monthBasic$,99/month Pro)
- Assign specific spaces to different paywalls
- Create subscription groups for easy upgrades/downgrades
- Set spaces to “Private” for paywall-gated access
- Configure post-purchase redirects to onboarding spaces

Phase 7: Invitations and Onboarding

- Generate unique invitation URLs with specific access levels
- Apply coupons or free trial periods to invitation links
- Create “Start Here” onboarding space with welcome video
- Provide guided steps for new members
- Automatically route new members to onboarding after purchase

Key Tools and Techniques

Platform Tools:

- Circle.so for community management
- Stripe for payment processing
- YouTube/Vimeo for video hosting

Organization Techniques:

- Use Space Groups to keep sidebar clean and intuitive
- Implement Card view for resource libraries
- Use Feed view for active discussions

Engagement Techniques:

- Encourage RSVPs for events to increase attendance
- Provide calendar reminders for event participation
- Enable automatic replay posting for missed events

Marketing Techniques:

- Use “Private” spaces to show upgrade potential
- Create tiered access to encourage upgrades
- Leverage custom domains for brand consistency

Actionable Insights

Standardized Layouts: Use Card view for resource libraries and Feed view for active discussions to create consistent user experience.

Automation Benefits: Always enable “Automatically post recording to event” to save time and provide immediate value to members who missed live sessions.

Simplified Onboarding: A single welcome post with clear next steps reduces member confusion and churn significantly.

Self-Service Subscriptions: Leverage subscription groups to allow members to manage their own upgrades without admin intervention.

Professional Branding: Setting up a custom domain (e.g., community.yourbrand.com) is essential for a professional, seamless brand experience.

Paywall Strategy: Use “Private” rather than “Secret” spaces to show members what they could access if they upgrade, creating motivation for conversion.

VIDEO 3: Skool.com Advanced Features and Settings Guide

URL: https://youtu.be/iEbNgI07DNU?si=kiIddSIbO-sfD10E

Core Features Demonstrated

Dashboard and Analytics:

- Community dashboard tracking member count
- Monthly Recurring Revenue (MRR) monitoring
- Engagement level metrics
- Member retention rates
- Page visitor statistics
- Conversion rate tracking

Core Platform Components:

- Classroom for courses and training
- Calendar for events and scheduling
- Members tab for management and filtering
- Leaderboards for gamification
- Map feature for member location visualization
- About page as community landing page

Step-by-Step Setup Process

Phase 1: Initial Community Setup

- Create account and name community
- Provide email address
- Activate the group
- Follow built-in “Set up your group” checklist:
  - Watch 2-minute intro video
  - Set cover image
  - Invite at least 3 people
  - Write first post
  - Download Skool mobile app

Phase 2: Discovery and SEO Optimization

- Use up to 11 keywords for search optimization

- Optimize community description for discoverability
- Configure About page with media and descriptions
- Ensure non-members can preview community before joining

Phase 3: Pricing Model Configuration

- **Free Model:** Open to everyone
- **Subscription Model:** Monthly or annual recurring fees
- **Freemium Model:** Free entry with paid upgrades available
- **Tiered Model:** Multiple levels of paid access (Standard, Premium, VIP)
- **One-Time Payment:** Fixed price for lifetime or limited access
- Set pricing based on business model and target audience

Phase 4: Payment Processing Setup

- Link Stripe account for transaction handling
- Configure payout frequency
- Set up payment method collection
- Monitor transaction history and MRR

Phase 5: Affiliate Program Configuration

- Set commission rates (10%-50% range)
- Reward members for referring paying clients
- Track affiliate performance and payouts
- Create incentive structure for member referrals

Phase 6: Plugin Configuration (Pro Features)

- **Membership Questions:** Ask up to 3 vetting questions or email capture
- **Auto DM:** Send automated welcome messages to new members
- **Zapier Integration:** Connect to CRMs or email autoresponders
- **Tracking Pixels:** Add Meta or Google pixels for ad tracking

Phase 7: Engagement and Growth Techniques

- **Gamified Unlocking:** Use level unlock for courses to motivate engagement

- **Tiered Access:** Set up levels where higher tiers include all lower-tier content
- **Email Broadcasts:** Email posts to all members (once every 72 hours)
- **Course Importing:** Use Course Key to duplicate or move courses between communities
- **Native Video Hosting:** Upload and store videos directly on Skool platform

Key Tools and Techniques

Analytics and Tracking:

- Dashboard metrics for performance monitoring
- Stripe integration for payment tracking
- Meta and Google pixels for ad performance
- Email broadcast for member communication

Content Management:

- Native video hosting to reduce third-party dependencies
- Course importing for efficient content migration
- Level-based content unlocking for engagement

Growth Strategies:

- Affiliate program for organic growth
- Gamification for member retention
- Email broadcasts for high-reach communication
- Tiered pricing for revenue optimization

Actionable Insights

Privacy Settings: Always default to **Private** if protecting content is important. “Public” makes the group searchable on Google and viewable by non-members, which can confuse paid community members.

Icon Design: Keep icons simple and text-free since they appear very small. Ensure cover images (1284x576) are professional and recognizable.

Spam Prevention: Enable plugins requiring members to reach Level 2 or 3 before posting or chatting to prevent “hit-and-run” spammers.

Conversion Strategy: For high-ticket coaching, use the Freemium model to build trust with free content before upselling to paid tiers.

Traffic Diversification: While Skool's Discovery provides free traffic, supplement with external sources like YouTube or Instagram for sustainable growth.

Event Attendance: Always toggle the "Remind members by email 1 day before" setting for calendar events to maximize attendance.

Pricing Flexibility: Offer multiple pricing models to cater to different audience segments and maximize revenue potential.

Comparative Analysis: Skool vs. Circle

Feature	Skool	Circle
Setup Complexity	Moderate	More Complex
Pricing	$99/month	Variable (depends on plan)
Video Hosting	Native hosting available	Third-party (YouTube, Vimeo)
Live Events	Basic calendar events	Advanced (Live Stream & Live Room)
Course Structure	Lessons in folders	Modules and Lessons
Gamification	Levels, points, leaderboards	Points, levels, badges, leaderboards
Payment Processing	Stripe integration	Native Stripe integration
Customization	Moderate	High (Space Groups, multiple layouts)
Community Discovery	Built-in search	Built-in search
Affiliate Program	Available	Not mentioned
Automation	Zapier, Auto DM, Pixels	Webhooks, automation workflows

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Key Takeaways for Community Builders

Universal Best Practices

1. **Onboarding is Critical:** Invest in clear, structured onboarding that guides new members through initial steps and encourages participation.
2. **Gamification Drives Engagement:** Use points, levels, and rewards to incentivize member participation and prevent community stagnation.
3. **Content Organization:** Use clear hierarchies (folders, space groups, modules) to help members navigate and find relevant content.
4. **Live Interaction:** Schedule regular events and live sessions to create real-time engagement and build community bonds.
5. **Strategic Pricing:** Choose pricing models that align with your audience and business goals (free, freemium, tiered, or one-time).
6. **Payment Integration:** Use Stripe for seamless payment processing and reliable transaction handling.
7. **Email Communication:** Leverage email broadcasts and reminders to keep members engaged and informed.
8. **Analytics Monitoring:** Regularly review metrics (member growth, MRR, retention, engagement) to guide strategy adjustments.

Platform-Specific Recommendations

Choose Skool if:

- You want simplicity and quick setup
- You prefer native video hosting
- You need built-in affiliate program functionality
- Your community is primarily discussion-based

Choose Circle if:

- You need advanced customization options
- You want sophisticated live streaming capabilities
- You require complex course structures

- You need flexible space organization

Implementation Roadmap

Month 1: Foundation

- Set up community with proper branding
- Create onboarding content and welcome post
- Configure basic pricing model
- Set up payment processing

Month 2: Content and Engagement

- Build initial course content
- Schedule regular calendar events
- Implement gamification system
- Create member engagement strategy

Month 3: Growth and Optimization

- Launch affiliate program
- Optimize discovery keywords
- Analyze metrics and adjust strategy
- Implement automation workflows

Month 4+: Scale and Refine

- Expand content library
- Develop tiered offerings
- Optimize conversion funnels
- Build sustainable growth engine

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